

THE FINEPRINT

» ₹30,000 crore allocated for next phase of UDAN scheme

» Aim is connecting Tier II/III/IV cities

» Focus on tapping passengers undertaking over seven-hour train and bus journeys

» Under 70 aircraft in regional space, which can easily absorb up to 350

» Mixed fleet of ATRs, Embraer Jets, and Twin Otters

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BEFORE STARTING FLY91 out of Goa, founder Manoj Chacko's team studied the cases of two dozen failed airlines from around the world to get a fix on what works and what doesn't in aviation, a dicey business at the best of times.

Chacko says he found the same depressing story repeat itself—a lack of sufficient emphasis on the fundamentals of aviation. “It was not a lack of enthusiasm or effort or hard work. They never got the fundamentals right. You need cost leadership, ability to set up a network and the

right financial structure,” he says.

Chacko is determined to avoid getting the fundamentals wrong. Fly91, which started operations in March 2024, aims to break even by FY26.

It isn't the only regional carrier to take to skies. Star Air, run by Maharashtra-based Godhawat group, posted a profit in FY25, even as major Indian carriers have been facing financial and operational challenges. Ahmedabad-based IndianOne Air, the first scheduled airline in India to operate a single-engine aircraft, recently signed a letter of intent with aircraft manufacturer De Havilland Canada to acquire up to 10 Twin Otter Series 300-G aircraft. That is not all. A few more entities eyeing last-mile air connectivity—Shankh Air, Alhind, FlyExpress and Air

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Chhatrapati Rajaram Maharaj Airport in Kolhapur, Maharashtra

